

Quirky subjects in Korean psych constructions: A case-based analysis

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- 1. Introduction.** Psych predicates in **base-form** exhibit two case frames denote mental states involving an experiencer and a theme (Jung 2014).
- (1) a. **Mimi-eykey** Inho-ka miw.ess-ta.
Mimi-DAT Inho-NOM hate.PAST-DECL
'Mimi disliked/hated Inho.' (Adapted from Kim 2016: (2a)) **[DAT-NOM] [Target]**
- b. **Mimi-ka** Inho-ka miw.ess-ta.
Mimi-NOM Inho-NOM hate.PAST-DECL
'Mimi disliked Inho.' **[NOM-NOM] [Comparison]**
- c. Mimi-ka Inho-lul miwe-**ha**.yss-ta.
Mimi-NOM Inho-ACC hate-do.PAST-DECL
'Mimi disliked Inho.' **[NOM-ACC] [Comparison]**
- The experiencer can **alternate** between the dative and the nominative case.
 - DAT-NOM is compared with the base-form NOM-NOM and the light verb NOM-ACC constructions.

2. Research questions.

- What is the structural position of the dative experiencer?
- How does DAT-NOM differ structurally from NOM-NOM and NOM-ACC psych constructions?
- How is nominative case assigned to the theme?

3. Previous analyses.

3.1. **NOM-ACC** vs. **DAT-NOM** in Jung (2014)

- (2) a. NOM-ACC [Class I] b. DAT-NOM [Class III]
- Diagram for (2a) NOM-ACC [Class I]:

```
graph TD
    vP --> DP
    vP --> v'
    DP --> experiencer
    v' --> VP
    v' --> vDO
    VP --> DP
    VP --> V
    DP --> theme
```

Class I: v_{DO} introduces the external argument;
the theme receives accusative by v_{DO} .

→ **v_{DO} is usually agentive, but it licenses the experiencer in (2a).**
→ **Why does the experiencer get the dative case and the theme a nominative case in (2b)?**
→ **Why is the experiencer an external argument in (2a) but not in (2b)?**
- Diagram for (2b) DAT-NOM [Class III]:

```
graph TD
    vP --> VP
    vP --> vBE
    VP --> DP
    VP --> v'
    v' --> experiencer
    v' --> DP
    v' --> V
    DP --> theme
```

Class III: v_{BE} is stative and introduces no external argument in Spec-VP.

3.2. **NOM-NOM** vs. **DAT-NOM** in Cho (2024)

- (3) a. NOM-NOM b. DAT-NOM [Class III]
- Diagram for (3a) NOM-NOM:

```
graph TD
    TP --> T'
    T' --> vP
    T' --> T
    vP --> Subj_i
    vP --> v'
    v' --> VP
    v' --> vBE
    VP --> t_i
    VP --> v
    v --> VP
    v --> vEXP
    VP --> Obj
    VP --> V
```

Diagram for (3b) DAT-NOM [Class III]:

```
graph TD
    TP --> T'
    T' --> vP
    T' --> T
    vP --> Subj_i
    vP --> v'
    v' --> VP
    v' --> vBECOME
    VP --> t_i
    VP --> v
    v --> VP
    v --> vEXP
    VP --> Obj
    VP --> V
```

 - v_{EXP} introduces the experiencer external argument;
 - v_{BE} assigns stative reading;
 - v_{BECOME} licenses eventive reading.

→ **How does the theme get nominative case?**
→ **Why is a separate v_{EXP} necessary instead of a non-agentive Voice head (Kratzer 1996)?**

Selected reference.

- Burger, Jacob, and Benjamin Bruening. *to appear*. Unaccusative Applicatives, Nominal Licensing, and a Hybrid theory of Case. Ms.
- Hong, Ki-Sun. 1991. *Argument Selection and Case-Marking in Korean*. Ph.D. dissertation: Stanford University, CA, USA.
- Kim, Kyumin. 2016. A unified analysis of existentials in Korean as pseudo-transitives. *Studia Linguistica* 70(2): 144-179.
- Kratzer, Angelika. 1996. Severing the external argument from its verb. In *Phrase Structure and the Lexicon*, ed. Johan Rooryck and Laurie Zaring: 109-137. Dordrecht: Kluwer Academic Publishers.
- Marantz, Alec. 1991. Case and licensing. In *Proceedings of the Eastern States Conference on Linguistics (ESCOL)* 8: 234-253. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University.

3.3. Applicative analysis of **DAT-NOM** in Kim (2016)

- (4) DAT-NOM [Class III]
- Diagram for (4) DAT-NOM [Class III]:

```
graph TD
    TP --> DP
    TP --> T'
    DP --> experiencer_i
    T' --> T
    T' --> ApplP
    T --> past
    ApplP --> t_i
    ApplP --> Appl'
    Appl' --> Appl
    Appl' --> VP
    Appl --> AG_DAT_
    Appl --> DP
    DP --> theme
    VP --> V
```
- The dative experiencer is introduced by Appl and functions as the structural subject that occupies Spec-TP.
- **Why should the experiencer be introduced by Appl rather than Voice?**
→ **How is nominative on the theme derived?**

3.3.1. Appl heads only introduce stimuli (theme), never the experiencer.

- (5) Sasak (Austronesian, Indonesia; Burger & Bruening *to appear*: (25), originally from McDonnell & Truong 2024: (39))
- a. Ie taku.
3SG afraid
'(S)he is afraid.'
- b. Ie takut-an berarak.
3SG afraid-APPL spider
'(S)he is afraid of spiders.'
- Cross-linguistically, overt applicatives introduce **themes**, not experiencers (Burger & Bruening *to appear*).
 - Kim's (2016) applicative analysis is **inconsistent** with this pattern.

4. Proposal.

- The dative experiencer is introduced by **Voice**;
- and does not need to be introduced by an alternative head (e.g., v_{EXP} , Appl).
- The dative experiencer is **not a structural subject**, unlike in the previous analyses.
- The theme receives **default nominative case** and does not occupy Spec-TP.
- DAT-NOM psych construction lacks a structural TP subject.

5. Subjecthood diagnostics target different grammatical properties.

Subjecthood is an **umbrella term** that encompasses TP-related properties, external argumenthood, and discourse prominence. **I adopt the view of split subjecthood** (Keenan 1976).

Subjecthood diagnostics (adopted from Hong (1991, 1994) and Lee et al. (2015))					
Structural subject		Consciousness and predication subject		Discourse prominence	
Honorific agreement	Obligatory control	<i>Caki</i> binding	Plural copying	Coordinated deletion	Adjunct control

Because base-form psych predicates are stative, **obligatory control cannot be tested directly** (the diagnostic requires the use of certain predicates involving proposal, such as *seltukhata* 'to persuade', *ceyanhata* 'to propose', etc. (Madigan 2008)). **Only honorific agreement is used to evaluate structural subjecthood in this paper.**

5.1. Honorific agreement.

- Honorific agreement occurs at the **T-level**, targeting the structural subject.
- (6) a. kyoswu-nim-kkeyse Inho-lul miwe-ha-s-yess-ta.
professor-HON-HON.NOM Inho-ACC hate-do-HON-PAST-DECL
'(The) Professor hated Inho.' **[NOM-ACC]**
- b. *kyoswu-nim-kkey Inho-ka miw-s-yess-ta.
professor-HON-HON.DAT Inho-NOM hate-HON-PAST-DECL
'(The) Professor hated Inho.' **[DAT-NOM]**
- c. kyoswu-nim-kkeyse Inho-ka miw-s-yess-ta.
professor-HON-HON.NOM Inho-NOM hate-HON-PAST-DECL
'(The) Professor hated Inho.' **[NOM-NOM]**
- Yang (1994) and subsequent work treat (6b) as grammatical.
 - All 15 native speakers consulted judged it **unacceptable**.
 - The present analysis accounts for the **latter** grammar.

5.2. 자기 (*caki*) binding.

- (7) a. Mimi-ka caki-lul coha-ha-n-ta.
Mimi-NOM self-ACC like-do.PRES-DECL
'Mimi likes herself.' **[NOM-ACC]**
- b. Mimi-eykey/-ka caki-ka coh-ta.
Mimi-DAT/-NOM self-NOM like-DECL
'Mimi likes herself.' **[DAT/NOM-NOM]**
- Binding *caki* does **not** distinguish structural subjecthood from discourse prominence;
 - it is compatible with dative experiencer functioning as the **discourse perspective holder** (Lee 2006).
 - Both** nominative and dative experiencers permit *caki* binding despite **differing structural positions**, suggesting that *caki* tracks discourse perspective rather than SpecTP.

5.3. Plural copying.

- Plural copying targets the subject of consciousness, rather than the TP-related syntax (An 2007, Lee et al. 2015).
- (8) a. haksayng-tul-i chayk-ul/chayk-tul-ul coha-ha.yss-ta.
student-PL-NOM book-ACC/book-PL-ACC like-do.PAST-DECL
'Students liked the book/the books.' **[NOM-ACC]**
- b. haksayng-tul-eykey chayk-i/chayk-tul-i coh-ass-ta.
student-PL-DAT book-NOM/book-PL-NOM like-PAST-DECL
'Students liked the book/the books.' **[DAT-NOM]**
- c. haksayng-tul-i chayk-i/chayk-tul-i coh-ass-ta.
student-PL-NOM book-NOM/book-PL-NOM like-PAST-DECL
'Students liked the book/the books.' **[NOM-NOM]**
- Plural copying patterns **identically** across all three constructions either with nominative or dative experiencer;
 - This diagnostic does **not** distinguish Spec-TP from Spec-VoiceP.

5.4. Coordinated deletion.

- (9) a. Mimi-ka Inho-lul coha-ha-ko e_i/s_j Juhee-lul silhe-ha-n-ta.
Mimi-NOM Inho-ACC like-do-CONJ Juhee-ACC hate-do.PRES-DECL
'Mimi_i likes Inho and e_i hates Juhee.' **[NOM-ACC]**
- b. Mimi-eykey Inho-ka coh-ko e_i/s_j Juhee-ka silh-ta.
Mimi-DAT Inho-NOM like-CONJ Juhee-NOM hate-DECL
'Mimi_i likes Inho and e_i hates Juhee.' **[DAT-NOM]**
- c. Mimi-ka Inho-ka coh-ko e_i/s_j Juhee-ka silh-ta.
Mimi-NOM Inho-NOM like-CONJ Juhee-NOM hate-DECL
'Mimi_i likes Inho and e_i hates Juhee.' **[NOM-NOM]**
- Coordinated deletion permits omission of discourse topics independently of TP position (Kim et al. 2024).
 - There is no difference in acceptability between experiencer cases - the diagnostic does not identify the structural subject.

5.5. Adjunct control.

- Adjunct control is independently sensitive to perspectival interpretation and discourse prominence (Hong 1991, 1994; Lee et al. 2015).
- (10) a. PRO_i/s_j elun-i-myense, Mimi-ka Inho-lul mwusewe-ha.yss-ta.
adult-COP-ADV Mimi-NOM Inho-ACC scared-do.PAST-DECL
'Although PRO_i being an adult, Mimi_i was scared of Inho_j.' **[NOM-ACC]**
- b. PRO_i/s_j elun-i-myense, Mimi-eykey Inho-ka mwusew.ess-ta.
adult-COP-ADV Mimi-DAT Inho-NOM scared.PAST-DECL
'Although PRO_i being an adult, Mimi_i was scared of Inho_j.' **[DAT-NOM]**
- c. PRO_i/s_j elun-i-myense, Mimi-ka Inho-ka mwusew.ess-ta.
adult-COP-ADV Mimi-NOM Inho-NOM scared.PAST-DECL
'Although PRO_i being an adult, Mimi_i was scared of Inho_j.' **[NOM-NOM]**
- Adjunct control does not distinguish the three constructions, since they behave the same.

5.6. Overview of subjecthood diagnostics.

Diagnostic	DAT-NOM	NOM-NOM	NOM-ACC
Honorific agreement	X	✓	✓
<i>Caki</i> binding	✓	✓	✓
Plural copying	✓	✓	✓
Coordination deletion	✓	✓	✓
Adjunct control	✓	✓	✓

Structural position: DAT ≠ NOM
Discourse: DAT = NOM
Dative experiencer = external argument, but not TP subject

6. A Voice-based analysis.

- (11)
- Diagram for (11):

```
graph TD
    TopP --> NP
    TopP --> Top'
    NP --> Mimi_eykey
    Top' --> TP
    Top' --> Top
    TP --> T'
    T' --> VoiceP
    T' --> T
    VoiceP --> t_i
    VoiceP --> Voice'
    Voice' --> VP
    Voice' --> Voice
    VP --> NP
    VP --> V'
    V' --> Inho_ka
    V' --> mipta
    V' --> DAT_agent_
```
- The experiencer is assigned inherent dative case by a **non-agentive Voice head** as an external argument (Kratzer 1996).
 - No syntactic requirement (e.g., honorific agreement) forces raising to Spec-TP.
 - The experiencer can **optionally** move up to Spec-TopP when licensed by the discourse.
 - Adopting **Dependent Case Theory** (Marantz 1991, Bobaljik 2008);
 - dative experiencer does not participate in case competition;
 - The theme is assigned the default case, which is the nominative case.
 - Since the theme is assigned case, it has no motivation to raise to Spec-TP.

7. Conclusion.

- The dative experiencer is an external argument in **SpecVoiceP**, not SpecTP.
- Only honorific agreement diagnoses TP subjecthood in psych constructions.
- Other diagnostics track discourse prominence or external argumenthood.
- A non-agentive Voice analysis explains the case pattern without introducing alternative heads such as v_{EXP} or Appl.